uncle of the present Chairman of HDFC Deepak Parekh, distinguished himself as one of ICICI's finest Chairmen.

Hasmukh Thakoredas Parekh was born on March 10, 1911, in Surat to Thakoredas and Chandangouri, the third of eight children and the second son. Thakoredas had six sons and two daughters. The family home was in the Morarjee Goculdas Chawl (now known as Sikka Nagar) in Bombay. The eldest son was Shantilal followed by Hasmukh, Jayantilal, Chandrakant, Sushil, and Devidas in that order. Thakoredas initially worked in a textile mill but an accident which crushed his thumb ended his career in the textile industry and he joined the Bank of India, then in existence for only three years. In 1911, when Sorabji Pochkhanawala left the Bank of India to start the Central Bank of India, Thakoredas followed him and was one of the first few employees of the new institution. (Deepak Parekh recalls his grandfather locking and opening the door of the Fort Branch of the Central Bank of India.)

Parekh was a student at Tutorial High School in Bombay and passed his matriculation examination of the University of Bombay in the first place. He joined Wilson College for a BA in Economics and made friends with, among others, M.L. Dantwala and Asoka Mehta, who later became respected economists in their own right. Dantwala topped the BA examination in 1930, Mehta in 1931, and Parekh in 1932. (Even though he placed first, he did not secure first class marks, testimony to the times when a high second-class was considered a meritorious achievement. Later, Parekh remarked that he always regarded himself as a high second-class student and not a first-class one.) Many years later Parekh gratefully acknowledged the benefit he had derived from the notes given to him by Dantwala. Parekh was to repay that favour when Dantwala was imprisoned because of his involvement in the freedom struggle. Dantwala was doing his MA and Parekh visited him in jail, regularly bringing him the study material he needed and also taking the draft chapters of Dantwala's thesis to his guide.

In those times there was nothing more prestigious than becoming an officer of the ICS. It was also the best way forward for a young man with ability and ambition but without any connections to give him a leg up in the world. Parekh wrote the ICS examination but failed to qualify. His father then sent him to England to study for and write the examination from there.